‘Government.’

Ragothaman showed them a photograph of the dismembered body of a man from the morgue. The mother could not check her tears. Both parents confirmed it was their son Haribabu. They had seen their son in that condition earlier at the hospital.

Ragothaman stepped out of the hut and waved at his assistant, Inspector Chelladurai. Ragothaman wanted to help Haribabu’s family. He asked Chelladurai to get some bread, biscuits, coffee and milk for the family.

To his surprise, Haribabu’s mother instantly objected. ‘No, no, no, sir. You are my guest, sir. Guests are like God. Let me do the honours, sir.’

She fished out a bundle of hundred-rupee notes from inside her white blouse, pulled one out and gave it to her daughter. ‘Get some biscuits and coffee.’

It was a revelation for the seasoned CBI investigator. Where did she get that much money from? The IO of the world’s most sensational case at that moment looked straight at the mother as he spoke. ‘Your son is gone. That’s very unfortunate. But if you can come up with any information about your son’s associates, you will be heavily rewarded. That’s my promise.’

The father was about to say something but the mother stopped him. Ragothaman took their leave without waiting for the coffee to arrive. After taking his seat in the Jeep, he told Chelladurai, ‘Appearances are always deceptive in our field of work, and things are rarely as they seem to be.’

After a breakfast of poori-kurma at Anand’s on Mount Road, Anirudhya called Verma. He said he was busy looking into Bhagwan Singh and that he might raid a place in connection with that. ‘Would you like to join me?’ he asked.

‘Yeah, when?’

‘Call me around eight at night?’

Both spoke for a while longer and then disconnected.